



Boys Love: The Evolutionary Dynamics, Strategies and Socio-Economic Capacity of Thailand's BL Media Industry

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I. Abstract

Thai Boys Love (BL) has grown significantly in the past decade and continues to grow both domestically and internationally. Little research exists on the Thai BL market and the different strategies companies use to promote their series. This paper aims to analyze the evolutionary dynamics and marketing strategies shaping Thailand's BL media industry. By applying game theory and replicator dynamics, we model the competition between authentic queer narratives and commercial fantasy storylines to examine how audience preferences and content reputation influence production decisions. Our findings reveal a critical threshold for authenticity in BL content, where authentic narratives dominate when supported above a certain frequency, reflecting tensions between profitability and representation. The study highlights the role of LGBTQ+ communities and broader audiences, discussing implications for future content production that balances commercial success with authentic portrayal of queer relationships. Ultimately, the research contributes to understanding how Thailand leads Southeast Asia in normalizing queer narratives and shaping media representation in this growing industry.

II. Introduction

Boy's Love, a content genre originating from Japan as yaoi, has become a highly competitive media landscape in Thailand, leading to its designation as the "Land of BL" (Lyajoon, 2024). However, BL had an unconventional track to prominence.

BL was introduced to Thailand in the late 1980s with pirated Japanese manga titles and quickly found a niche audience in the country (Bunyavejchewin, 2022). While mainstream manga quickly shifted to licensed publications after copyright lawsuits, BL manga continued to be largely pirated until the 2010s, partially due to concerns among publishers that its content might violate Thai criminal law regarding obscenity. Despite a temporary prohibition of BL manga from bookstores in 2006 following public anxiety over its "pornographic content" and the public visibility of male homoeroticism, major publishers like Bongkoch Publishing began licensing BL titles in 2014, recognizing its increasing popularity. This genre has since grown significantly, with billions of views reported on platforms like LINE TV by 2020 and an annual growth rate of 17% by 2025. This rapid expansion, however, creates a fundamental tension between profitability and authentic representation for industry players or companies.

Companies in this sector must navigate the diverse preferences of their consumer base, which primarily consists of two distinct segments: heterosexual female fans (*sao-wai*) and LGBTQ+ male fans (*hnum-wai*) (Michaels et al., 2024). *Sao-wai*, or yaoi girls, constitute the vast majority of BL fans in Thailand, representing 89% of survey respondents (Bunyavejchewin, 2022). These fans are frequently drawn to BL for a powerful emotional response, the absence of weak, stereotypical female protagonists common in other manga genres, ideals of love that cut across traditional power dynamics, and the aesthetic appeal (Zsila et al., 2018). *Sao-wai* also value BL for its escapism from gender-normative prescription, allowing them to explore sexual desires through male characters as surrogates (Bunyavejchewin, 2022). Notably, 69% of heterosexual women surveyed perceive BL narratives as largely accurate in representing gay relationships and character appearance (Michaels et al., 2024). However, these audiences largely misinterpret queer relationships and platforms create narratives catering to their oblique perspectives.

In contrast, *hnum-wai*, or yaoi boys, make up a smaller segment (11% of respondents, with a majority identifying as homosexual or bisexual (Bunyavejchewin, 2022)). While these fans also appreciate the escapism and identification BL offers and normalization of same-sex love (Bunyavejchewin, 2022), a disparity emerges in their perceptions of accuracy (Michaels et al., 2024). 79% of gay men believe that BL narratives do not accurately represent their relationships, and 72% disagree that gay people desire the appearance portrayed by BL characters.

This disparity underscores a strategic dilemma for content creators. Producers acknowledge this challenge, noting that gay men seek genuine portrayals of their experiences while fangirls are drawn to specific character types, romantic dynamics, or attractive actors (Michaels et al., 2024). Consequently, producers often face the difficult choice of prioritizing commercial appeal through specific character archetypes and attractive actors (fantasy narratives) to cater to the larger heterosexual female audience, sometimes over authentic representation (Michaels et al., 2024). This strategic choice is evident in the approach of

companies like GMMTV, which has effectively built a “BL Machine” (Lyajoon, 2024; Michaels et al., 2024). This machine combines extensive talent scouting and training with the creation of *khu-jin* (idolized celebrity couples) narratives, deliberately blurring the lines between fictional on-screen relationships and off-screen reality to amplify fan engagement and commodify queer romance (Michaels et al., 2024). Behavior like this is in line with the “fantasy” strategy.

In the competitive BL industry, companies' decisions regarding whether to lean into commercialized fantasy narratives or strive for authentic queer representation can be analyzed as strategic choices within a game theory framework. These choices involve understanding the varying payoffs derived from appealing to distinct market segments, anticipating the competitive actions of rival companies, and assessing the potential long-term impact on brand perception and fitness within the evolving Thai media landscape. We will employ game theory methods to evaluate these industry strategies, their payoffs, and their outcomes.

III. Model, Hypothesis, and Methods

i. Model

To capture the dynamic shifts in audience preferences within Thailand's BL media industry, an evolutionary game theory framework was adopted using replicator dynamics to model the competition between authentic queer narratives and commercialized fantasy portrayals. We treat this competition as a selection process shaped by both social influence and economic payoffs across two audience segments: LGBTQ+ viewers and the general population.

We define the state variable $x \in [0, 1]$ as the proportion of the population that supports or prefers authentic queer narratives, while $1 - x$ represents the proportion favoring commercialized fantasies. The rate of change in support for authentic narratives follows a replicator differential equation, defined below:

$$\dot{x} = x(1 - x)(f_C - f_D)$$

f_C and f_D represent the fitness (payoff) of authentic (C) and fantasy (D) narratives respectively. $\Delta f = f_C - f_D$ represents the change in payoffs, which is essentially the direction and the intensity of the shift in audiences.

To model the fitness of each of the strategies, we define f_C and f_D below:

$$\begin{aligned} f_C : \text{payoff of authentic} &= pN + qM + \gamma M \\ f_D : \text{payoff of fantasy} &= (1 - p)N + (1 - q)M \end{aligned}$$

In the equations above, N represents the number of audience members in the LGBTQ+ community, while M represents the number of audience members who are not in the LGBTQ+ community. p represents the probability of N choosing C , while q represents the probability of M choosing C , and γ represents the care factor for M in C , or how much non-LGBTQ+ members of the general population care and advocate for authentic narratives. We define p and q below:

$$p = \frac{r_c}{r_D + r_c}$$

$$r_c = \alpha_c e^{(1-x) \cdot t}$$

$$r_D = \alpha_D e^{(x-1) \cdot t}$$

and

$$q = \frac{\varphi_c}{\varphi_c + \varphi_D}$$

$$\varphi_c = \beta_c e^{(x-1) \cdot t}$$

$$\varphi_D = \beta_D e^{(1-x) \cdot t}$$

α and β are the initial reputation coefficients for each strategy in the two communities. The equations above model the environment effectively by encoding social learning, exponential sensitivity and real-life factors to changes in narrative dominance. This layered framework enables us to assess under what social and economic conditions different narratives come to dominate.

ii. Hypothesis

We hypothesize that commercialized fantasy narratives will dominate over authentic queer narratives within Thailand's BL media industry over time. This is due to three key mechanisms embedded in the evolutionary dynamics of audience behavior: wider market appeal and reach, reputation amplification and initial bias, and care factors.

Wider Appeal and Market Reach. Commercialized fantasies are designed for mass consumption. As a result, they not only avoid culturally or politically controversial elements, but they also lean into narratives or tropes that have previously seen commercial success. As a result, they appeal more to the general population (M), which constitutes a larger portion of the market compared to the LGBTQ+ audience group (N). Because the model weighs economic payoffs from both audience segments, the larger numerical advantage of M increases the total fitness f_D of fantasy narratives.

Reputation Amplification and Initial Bias. The reputational coefficients α_D and β_D , which govern the growth of reputation for fantasy narratives among both LGBTQ+ and general audiences, may initially be higher due to investment from the general media industry, idol-centric marketing, and globalized themes inspired by trending aesthetics such as K-Pop. These reputational advantages compound exponentially over time through terms like $e^{(x-1) \cdot t}$, which accelerates the adoption of fantasy narratives even when support for authentic narratives exists.

Care Factor and Saturation Effects. While LGBTQ+ audiences may express higher support and advocate more for authentic narratives, their influence is limited due to the inherent size of the community compared to the general population. Over time, if the proportion x that supports authentic narratives does not surpass a critical threshold, or if the care factor (γ) does not increase enough for authentic narratives to gain traction, the replicator dynamic $\dot{x} = x(1 - x)(f_C - f_D)$ will decrease as $f_D > f_C$.

In this way, fantasy narratives gain a structural advantage through favorable payoffs and reputation dynamics among the majority audience group. Therefore, unless social incentives or policies significantly shift the preferences of the general audience, we predict a long-run equilibrium in which fantasy narratives dominate the BL media landscape.

iii. Methods

To investigate which strategy would dominate in the real Thai BL market, we set the parameter values according to data from the real world. First, for the values of N and M , we determined the relative proportion of the LGBTQ+ population in Thailand, setting $N = 0.08$ and $M = 0.92$ to reflect accurate ratios (Limsamarnphun, 2018). Next, we investigated the Thai BL industry and sampled several of the most popular or prominent BLs of each category, the process for which will be described in greater detail below.

Data Collection. To quantitatively evaluate the relative dominance of authentic and commercialized fantasy BL narratives in Thailand, we conducted a comparative audience analysis of ten series, with five representing authentic queer storytelling and five representing commercial fantasy. Series were selected based on their cultural impact, online visibility, and critical attention between 2020 and 2024. The authentic category included *A Tale of Thousand Stars* (2021), *The Eclipse* (2022), *Moonlight Chicken* (2023), *Not Me* (2021), and *I Told Sunset About You* (2020). These series portray real struggles that members of the LGBTQ+ community often face such as coming out, homophobia, transphobia, and more. They also feature queer culture and activism, depicting an overall more holistic and realistic view of different LGBTQ+ experiences.



Figure 1. Posters of the authentic BLs chosen for data collection

The commercialized or fantasy narratives included *2gether* (2020), *TharnType* (2019), *Cutie Pie* (2022), *Love in the Air* (2022), and *KinnPorsche* (2022). These series featured more cliché storylines typical of romantic comedies or fantasies, heteronormative relationship dynamics that relegated gendered roles to queer couples, or fictitious worlds in which queer relationships are the norm, avoiding conversations about homophobia or queer culture in the context of real society.



Figure 2. Posters of the fantasy/commercialized BLs chosen for data collection

We collected audience engagement data across three platforms to capture quantitative data: Reddit, MyDramaList, and Twitter (X). We scraped user ratings, hashtags, like counts and view counts. This data-driven modeling approach allowed us to anchor evolutionary fitness in real-time audience behavior, stratified by identity.

Parameter Setting. Through this data collection, we determined the ratios for the initial reputation parameters α and β , defined below:

α_C : initial reputation of C in $N = 0.6$

α_D : initial reputation of D in $N = 0.4$

β_C : initial reputation of C in $M = 0.3$

β_D : initial reputation of D in $M = 0.7$

Time was set at $t = 1$, and the care factor γ was set to 0.1. This is because a national study revealed that despite the growing popularity of BLs in Thailand, LGBTQ+ individuals faced persistent experiences of stigma and discrimination, violence and exclusion (Pongruengphant, 2019). Thus, the general population's advocacy for authentic narratives was predicted to be low.

All dynamics were simulated across these parameters to analyze the evolution of media preference.

IV. Results

Our analysis yielded various insights into the competitive dynamics between authentic and fantasy portrayals in the Thai BL industry. Through the use of a replicator dynamics model, we examined how reputational feedback and different ratios of affective valuation (γ) shape the long-term sustainability of authentic content. All parameters were simulated under fixed initial conditions that reflect current industry realities, as described above.

Across most simulations, we observed that fantasy portrayals tend to dominate under default parameter settings, especially when the care factor γ is low. In our baseline scenario ($\gamma = 0.1$), despite strong preference for authenticity among LGBTQ+ audiences (with p consistently above 0.9), the overall fitness of authentic content remained lower than that of fantasy (Figure 3). This is primarily due to the overwhelming weight of the non-LGBTQ+ majority (92% of the audience) and the higher initial reputation of fantasy content within that group. The replicator equation under these conditions produced negative values of $\dot{x}$ across the entire domain of x , indicating that authentic content would decline in frequency regardless of its current prevalence and suggests a disadvantage defaulted into the media ecosystem.

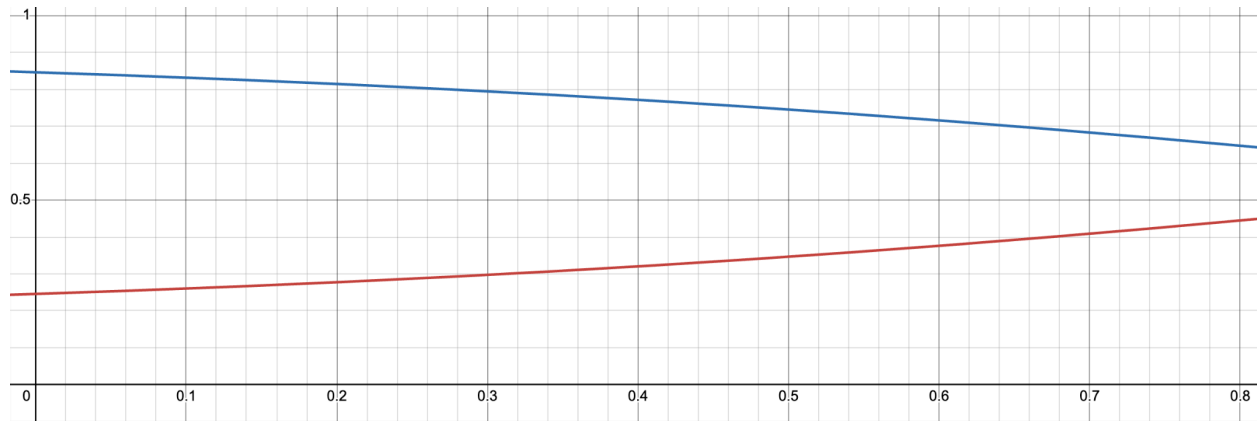


Figure 3. Red represents f_C and blue represents f_D at $\gamma = 0.1$

These results were consistent across multiple variances of initial reputational values. In scenarios where the initial reputation of authentic content within the non-LGBTQ+ audience was slightly improved (e.g., increasing β_C from 0.2 to 0.4), the required γ for crossover decreased substantially. Conversely, in simulations where the gap between β_C and β_D widened (when fantasy content had even stronger initial reputational advantages), the replicator dynamic remained negative even when γ approached 0.5. This indicates that without some kind of

reconfiguration of reputation, authenticity remains trapped in a structurally unsustainable position.

Visually, these dynamics were most evident in our payoff plots. Under low γ conditions, the fantasy payoff curve consistently lay above the authenticity curve, even when x was close to 0 (i.e., when authentic content was rare and therefore reputationally strong within its base). As γ increased, the f_c curve gradually lifted, eventually overtaking f_D around $\gamma = 0.38$ (Figure 4). Beyond this point, authenticity no longer requires exclusivity to maintain competitiveness as it could thrive even when it becomes more common due to broader affective support. This reflects that authentic content becomes scalable only when mass audiences are willing to assign value to representation and not just entertainment.

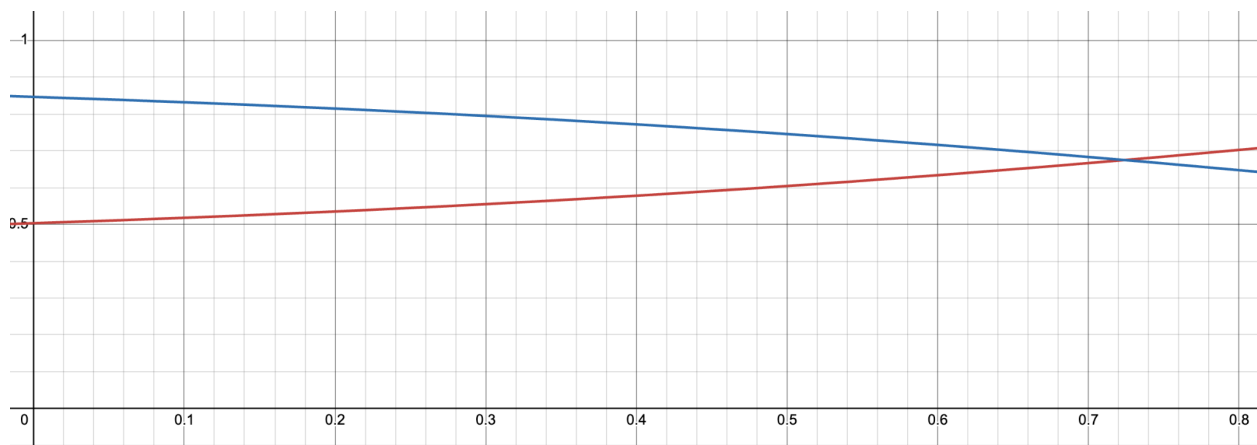


Figure 4. Red represents f_c and blue represents f_D at $\gamma = 0.38$

Our model helps explain why fantasy-driven BL shows dominate globally. These narratives often follow romantic formulas that avoid complex depictions of queer life. Such content benefits from high initial reputational values and faces little resistance in the market. In contrast, shows that attempt to depict queer identity, such as narratives that address homophobia, family pressure, or intersectional experiences, face multiple burdens: first, they must overcome a reputational disadvantage among the broader audience and then they must convince the general audience to care about authenticity in the first place.

Moreover, the model demonstrates how the market alone cannot guarantee equitable representation. Without deliberate changes to γ (through marketing or institutional interventions), authentic narratives will struggle to gain ground, regardless of their quality or significance. This shows the paradox of diversity in BL media: while platforms may seem to celebrate inclusivity, actual algorithmic and financial incentives often reward the most broadly consumed forms of queer expression.

Finally, the replicator equations are also useful tools for forecasting industry trends. If current reputational values and affective preferences remain stable, we can expect fantasy portrayals to continue dominating the Thai BL industry. However, if social movements, creator

activism, or shifts in global discourse lead to increases in γ or improvements in the reputation of authenticity in general audiences, we may see a gradual increase in the viability of authentic narratives. This shift would not occur instantaneously, but the nonlinear structure of the model suggests that once the critical γ threshold is passed, small cultural shifts could trigger significant and self-sustaining changes in content production. Our model demonstrates that the prevalence of authentic content in BL media is not solely a function of consumer taste, but rather shaped by structural market conditions and reputational feedback. Authenticity is not an inherently unfavorable strategy, but it does require a reassessment of how value is assigned within the media industry and general population. Only through such changes can authentic queer storytelling achieve both visibility and sustainability when faced with commercial pressures.

In this way, as predicted in our hypothesis and supported by our model, commercialized fantasy narratives ultimately dominate over authentic queer narratives. However, this outcome does not necessarily indicate a lack of real-world support for LGBTQ+ communities. Rather, it reflects the structural dynamics of media consumption and market influence. Notably, recent political developments in Thailand—including growing legal recognition and public advocacy for LGBTQ+ rights—suggest that cultural sentiment may be shifting in ways that affirm and support queer communities, even if such support is not reflected in the media industry.

V. Discussion

Earlier this year, Thailand made history by passing the Marriage Equality Act on January 23, 2025, and became the first Southeast Asian country to legalize same-sex marriage (NPR, 2025; International Bar Association, 2025). Previously, same-sex couples had no formal way to register their partnerships or claim spousal benefits (Government of Thailand, 2024). By amending the Civil and Commercial Code, specifically swapping out the classifications of “man and woman” and “husband and wife” for “individuals” and “marriage partners,” the Act finally created a clear and legal path for marriage equality. After parliament approved the bill in 2024, it received royal assent in August. On the first day of implementation in late January, more than 1,800 same-sex couples signed their marriage licenses (Reuters, 2025).



Figure 4. Thousands gathered in Bangkok for the city's Pride Parade on June 1, 2024.

This aligns closely with the mere-exposure effect: repeated, positive portrayals of a minority group can create a sense of empathy amongst non-LGBTQ+ communities (American Psychological Association, 2020). BL dramas show everyday events that a majority of the audience can relate to like studying late with friends, navigating family expectations, celebrating first kisses, but within a melodramatic framework that entertains viewers across age and social groups (Michaels et al., 2024; Koktail Magazine, 2024). Viewers often comment that the heartbreak, the confessions, and the celebrations feel so genuine that they spark real conversations away from the screen. On social media platforms such as Twitter (X), Instagram, and TikTok, hashtags like #ThaiBL and #2getherTheSeries trend across Southeast Asia, driving fan art, reaction videos, and heartfelt testimonials from both LGBTQ+ and straight-allied viewers (ABC News Australia, 2022). In households where queer topics were once taboo, BL content has provided a conversational entry point, challenging long-held stereotypes by presenting same-sex affection as a normalized, relatable experience (Reuters, 2025). Surveys from 2023 and 2024 indicate that over 70 percent of Thai respondents, especially those under 30, support legal recognition of same-sex unions (Pew Research Center, 2025). Activists recognized this trend and deliberately incorporated BL references into their campaigns; for instance, a high-profile billboard in central Bangkok proclaimed, “Just like Korn and Mew, love is love,” directly appealing to a generation already steeped in BL storylines (The Guardian, 2025). By the time lawmakers debated the Marriage Equality Act, ignoring the growing acceptance on screen would have risked alienating a culturally savvy electorate that had come to see queer relationships as part of mainstream entertainment (Amnesty International, 2024).

Many fantasy narratives fetishize BL relationships to appeal primarily to heterosexual female viewers and sideline issues like trans rights and systemic discrimination (Chulletin News, 2022; Michaels et al., 2024). By centering on youthful and conventionally attractive characters, usually university students with supportive families, the genre didn't always reflect the broader spectrum of LGBTQ+ experiences. Nonbinary, older, or socioeconomically marginalized individuals rarely saw their realities mirrored onscreen (Chulletin News, 2022). The reason why series such as *2gether* (2020) were able to become such phenomena in conservative Asian countries was because their presentation of queerness was mostly unrecognizable to real queer people, stripped of any true notion of queer sexuality or the realities of homophobia. Yet despite the fact that BL dramas sometimes prioritize romantic escapism over “authentic” depictions, or perhaps because of this, they played a crucial role in opening doors. The sheer popularity of these commercially palatable shows meant that conversations about same-sex love, family acceptance, and even queer challenges reached audiences who might never have sought out LGBTQ+ content otherwise. In other words, while the full, nuanced picture wasn't always on display, BL's success in normalizing same-sex romance helped lay the groundwork for both social empathy and, ultimately, legal change.

Together, Thailand's legalization of same-sex marriage cannot be fully explained without acknowledging the cultural impact of BL media and dramas. By normalizing queer romance through everyday depictions of affection, conflict, and resolution, BL narratives can be credited for providing Thai and other societies emotional entry points to develop empathy. This dynamic highlights BL's role as a soft power. It not only elevated Thailand's cultural standing but also pressured lawmakers to align legal frameworks with evolving societal attitudes. Moving forward,

BL producers face the critical task of deepening narrative authenticity—ensuring stories transcend romantic idealization to encompass a wider spectrum of queer experiences, including trans identities, socioeconomic disparities, and mental health issues. In doing so, BL dramas will continue to address LGBTQ+ issues both on screen and as catalysts for lasting social and legal progress.

VI. Conclusion

Dynamics within the BL industry are not merely a result of audience preference but emerge from structural imbalances in reputational dynamics, market segmentation, and cultural valuation. While LGBTQ+ audiences express support for authentic queer representation, their demographic minority limits their impact without broader shifts in mass audience care or institutional intervention. Our replicator dynamics demonstrate that only when authenticity is valued beyond niche consumption can it become competitively viable—in other scenarios, fantasy narratives always dominate. However, this does not necessarily mean lack of social progress, as the palatability of BL led more members of general audiences to broach conversations about LGBTQ+ communities and individuals, ultimately impacting legislative and social advancement.

As BL media continues to influence both cultural sentiment and legislative change, the future of the genre hinges on producers' ability to balance profitability with representation. A recalibration of value, where authenticity is not only seen as meaningful but also marketable, is essential for sustaining diverse, inclusive storytelling that reflects the full complexity of queer lives.

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